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New Evidence About The Strolling Actor George Jolly (1613–ca. 1683)

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ABSTRACT
The present article is essentially based on two unexplored notarial acts preserved in the City Archives at Rotterdam, both of which contain new evidence about George Jolly (1613–ca. 1683), the "last" and most famous of English wandering players on the continent. Dated 24 and 27 August 1646, these acts establish the earliest known dates by which Jolly had made his appearance in the Low Countries. Apart from providing us with the names of two of Jolly's fellow-actors, the same documents also shed light on his troupe's brief association with the company led by Jan Baptist van Fornenbergh (1624–1697), one of the most prominent Dutch actors and theatrical directors of the period. A disagreement over an (unresolved?) financial issue, brought before the Rotterdam "Vreedemakers Camer", probably caused the break-up of their united company, whose repertory of comedies and tragedies, performed in the spring/summer of 1646, cannot unfortunately be reconstructed.

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George Jolly; Jan Baptist van Fornenbergh; English and Dutch strolling actors; seventeenth century

Of the host of early seventeenth-century English wandering players who tried their fortunes on the continent, George Jolly (bap. 1613) has undoubtedly received the most intense and long-lasting scholarly attention. His chequered career, which is traditionally taken to have consisted of two distinct phases, one on either side of the Restoration, needs not be rehearsed in any great detail. Having arrived in France and the Low Countries in the mid-1640s at the latest, Jolly by 1647 headed his own sizeable company of players, who like their wandering forebears in the preceding decades, probably performed both in English and in various local languages. A tireless traveller, Jolly soon became a well-respected actor and the resourceful (but contentious) leader of various troupes performing in German-speaking lands and in German cities, including Cologne in 1649 and 1655, and especially Frankfort and its surroundings throughout the 1650s. Even if his career had been cut short by the Restoration, his theatrical experimentations, such as the introduction of actresses and the use of operatic scenery, would have earned him the reputation of an innovator and cultural carrier, who contributed to no small extent to the emergence of a "native" German theatrical tradition. Shortly after the Restoration Jolly was granted a license by Charles II to form an acting company, a favour which made him a rival to Sir William Davenant and Thomas Killigrew, who had

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already obtained a royal monopoly on all theatrical activities in London in August 1660. For several years Davenant and especially Killigrew attempted by all possible means, both legal and underhand, to have Jolly's patent recalled. By way of (temporary) settlement of the disputes, Jolly was given the directorship of the Nursery playhouse, a training school for fledgling actors, in Gibbons's Tennis Court, in 1667. Meanwhile he continued his activities as a wandering player in the English provinces, appearing in Cambridge in 1662 and in Norwich in 1663. However, the disputes with Killigrew did not abate until at least 1674, when he claimed money long since owed to him by Killigrew. Around this time Jolly's name disappeared from the records. He is believed to have died, possibly under impoverished conditions, before March 1683. Jolly's significance in English and continental theatre history has been well summed up by Leslie Hoston, who pointed out that "Master George Jolly" was

> the last of the famous English strollers in Germany; the first man to introduce actresses to the stage of Frankfurt-am-Main; the first English manager to develop the operatic form (preceding Davenant by several years); and, finally the actor who had played "before the crowned heads of Europe."[1]

Since the publication of Hotson's work almost a century ago, relatively little has been added to our knowledge of Jolly's career prior to 1650, and his earliest appearance on the continental scene has remained shrouded in mists.[2] Hotson thought it "possible that Jolly had left England several years before 1648" and that "[h]e may well have been one of the Prince of Wales's company of English actors in Paris which, in November 1646, was reported dissolved for want of pay."[3] Other theatre historians, including Herbert Junkers, E. F. Kossmann, Harry R. Hoppe, and J. G. Riewald have all approximately dated Jolly's presence in the Low Countries in the year 1646.[4] In his investigation of Jolly's activities in Germany between 1648 and 1660, Robert J. Alexander sensibly noted that, despite the educated guesses made by theatre historians about Jolly's presence *in German-speaking areas* in April 1648, the actor's first appearance there that can be accurately dated is 31 March 1649, when he asked permission to perform in Cologne.[5] Alexander's survey of Jolly's career had the added virtue of demonstrating that, in the absence of substantial documentary evidence, all years and/or dates prior to 31 March 1649 in or on which the actor is thought to have performed *in the Low Countries* can only be regarded as tentative. To date, the lingering uncertainty with respect to Jolly's itineraries and his contacts in the mid-1640s is aptly summed up in the 2004 *DNB* article on the actor: "[a]t some time before 1647 Jolly moved to continental Europe … as the leader of a variety of acting troupes. Initially he may have joined his colleagues

[1]Hotson, *Commonwealth and Restoration Stage,* 194. Most of my introductory paragraph is based on Hotson and on Astington, "Jolly."

[2]Minor contributions include Bentley, *Jacobean and Caroline Stage,* 483-484; and Scanlan, "Notes". On Jolly's birthdate, see Astington, "Two Seventeenth-Century Actors," 2–5.

[3]Hotson, *Commonwealth and Restoration Stage,* 21, 167. Prince Charles's company resided at The Hague from November 1644 until about February 1645, when some or all of them moved to Paris. Hotson's suggestion that Jolly was a member of this company has been accepted by Limon, *Gentlemen,* 59.

[4]Junkers, *Niederländische Schauspieler*, 20 (note 5), 65; Kossmann, *Das niederländische,* 104 (note 1); Kossmann, *Nieuwe bijdragen,* 142; Hoppe, "English Actors," 318–319; Hoppe, "George Jolly", 265–266; and Riewald, "New Light", 88.

[5]Alexander, ""George Jolly", 32–33, 40–45. Apparently unaware of Alexander's work, Astington has noted that Gideon Gellius (one of Jolly's Latinized names used in Germany) "first turns up as a performer at the annual fair at Frankfurt in September 1649." See "Two Seventeenth-Century Actors," 2–5.

who had gone to perform for the English royalist community in exile, first at The Hague, then in Paris, between 1644 and 1646."[6]

Two notarial acts, dated at Rotterdam on 24 and 27 August 1646, provide us with the earliest incontrovertible evidence we possess with respect to Jolly's stay and his professional associations in Holland. Passed before notary Arnout Hofflant, the act of 24 August is a declaration made on Jolly's behalf by two of his fellow-actors.[7] I provide a slightly abbreviated English translation of this document:

Today, on the 24th of August of the year 1646, have appeared before me, Arnout Hofflant, etc. Johannis Weijt, 50 years old, and Joris Bentler, 22 years old or of about that age, who have declared with true words instead of a solemn oath at the request of Joris Lollijffer that they, the deponents, have played next to one Jean Babtista as a company at fairs as well as in comedies and tragedies, and that they have been in contract with each other; [they have also declared that] Babtista aforesaid, who owes the requestor [i.e. Jolly] a debt of sixty guilders for clothes and advanced money, has now gone to the fair at Gouda with his company without the slightest reason and without any intention of [illegible word] this advance. Thus ending their deposition, willing to confirm this with an oath ... Signed: Johanis Waid, Joris Bentele.[8]

Adding to the amazing variety of names under which George Jolly, born in March 1613 as George Gellye, was to go on the continent (including Jolliphus, Jolifus, and Gellifus), the Dutch notary's clerk managed to produce what must be the most idiosyncratic form so far recorded—"Lollijffer", presumably based on his misreading of the initial "J" as "L".[9] More importantly, the act reveals that by the summer of 1646 Jolly belonged to (or headed?) a troupe of actors, whose size and composition are unfortunately not specified. But the names of two of his companions are here interestingly revealed (see Figure 1). John Wayde (Waite or Wade, ca. 1596–died 1671) was an older actor, who long before the outbreak of the Civil Wars had started out on his continental career and settled down at Utrecht, where he married a Dutchwoman, presumably in February 1625.[10] As early as 1617, Wayde had performed at Warsaw, and in July 1619 at Gdańsk,

[6]Astington, "Jolly". See also Astington, "Actors and the Court," 15–17.

[7]Covering the period 1585–1811, the extensive collection of Rotterdam notarial acts is organized according to the successive notaries' date of appointment by the Court of Holland. The documents are contained in the (roughly) chronologically ordered "personal" volumes compiled by each notary. Arnout Hofflant, who was appointed on 28 April 1626, had a long career: his minutes cover the period 1 March 1627–27 August 1659. Henk Gras has referred to this act in passing; see "Wat er aan de Schouwburg voorafging," 164, 204. But Gras appears to have been unaware of the identity of Waid, Bentley, and "Joris Lollijffer" and their relevance to seventeenth-century English theatrical history.

[8]SAR1. 18: Notarissen te Rotterdam en daarin opgegane gemeenten. Inv. 264: Notaris Arnout Hofflant. Akte no. 387, p. 551. In translation, I have omitted a few words in the concluding stereotyped formula, as indicated with three dots; for the sake of comprehensibility, I have also introduced some punctuation marks and added a few words between square brackets. The integral Dutch text (not counting two or three illegible words) reads as follows: "Op huijden den 24^{n} aug Anno 1646 compareerden voor mij Arnout Hofflant etc. Johannis Weijt out 50 Jaeren, ende Joris Bentler out 22 jaeren off elcx daer omtrent ende verclaerden met ware woorden in plaetse van solemnelen eede ter requisitie van Joris Lollijffer waerachtich te wesen dat sij deposanten nevens eenen Jean Babtista in Compagnie hebben gespeelt op kermissen als andere Commedien en tragedien, ende met den anderen in contract sijn geweest, ende dat de voorn: Babtista soo over cleedingen, verschoote Penningen als anders is schuldich gebleven aende Req^{t} de somme van t'sestich gul: ende nu naer de Goutsche kermis met haer Comp^{e} sonder eenige de minste oorsaeke is gescheijden sonder dat de voorn: Babtista desen aengelde (?) begeerde te [illegible word] eijndig: hier mede haer (?) depositie aengevende (?) t'selve des noot met ede te beregtigen.

[9]For other equally bewildering spellings, see Hotson, *Commonwealth and Restoration Stage,* 167; and Katritzky, 275.

[10]UA1. 711: Burgerlijke stand gemeente Utrecht, p. 44. The evidence is confusing. The banns of "Johan Waid, from England [my translation] and Jannechjen Jans van Es, from Utrecht" are listed under date 28 March 1624. The date of their marriage in the church of St. Gertrude, as retroactively recorded in the marginal note in the same entry, reads "27 February 1625," which is unusually long after the banns were proclaimed. The average time gap between

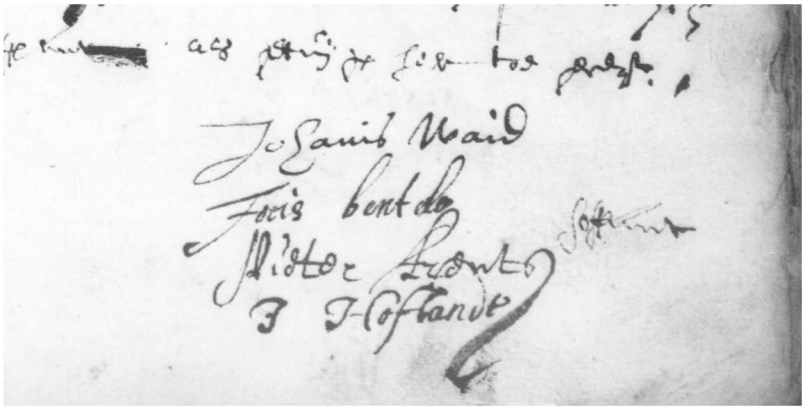

Figure 1. Stadsarchief Rotterdam. 18: Notarissen te Rotterdam en daarin opgegane gemeenten. Inv. 264: Arnout Hofflant, 4 March 1643–31 December 1648. Act no. 387: attestation dated 24 August 1646, p.551. Signatures of John Wayde and George Bentley.

with a troupe of actors and musicians under the management of Richard Jones (fl. 1583-1638).[11] He carried on his profession for several decades afterwards, as a member of various companies which travelled through Germany, the Baltic area, and Scandinavia. Together with William Roe, Wayde visited Gdańsk again, presumably in 1643, and certainly in 1644 and 1647. While on their way to Sweden, the Wayde-Roe troupe also stopped at Königsberg in 1644 and 1647, and at Riga in January 1648.[12] And on January 1650 the sum of 120 florins was recorded in payment for a performance recently given at Brussels before the archduke Leopold-William by Wayde and his company.[13] His hitherto unnoticed stay at Rotterdam (and elsewhere in the Netherlands?) in the summer of 1646 was evidently no more than a brief intermezzo in his more wide-ranging travels—an intermezzo which saw him acting in diverse dramatic genres ("at fairs as well as in comedies and tragedies") in his adopted country.

George Bentley (born ca. 1624), on the other hand, would have been a neophyte actor in August 1646, one about whose pre-1652 career we are poorly informed. When exactly he crossed over to the continent has never been determined; perhaps, like other exiled actors, he did so in or about 1642. By 24 August 1646, however, he certainly resided at Rotterdam, where on 5 September he hired one Robert Vincin (or Vinson?) as an apprentice, agreeing to train him for a period of four successive years.[14] If Bentley did so in his capacity as an ordinary member of Jolly's troupe (and not as a leading actor or co-manager), this would constitute interesting evidence that the hiring of apprentices was

the proclamation of the banns and the marriage was between one and three weeks, as appears from the surrounding entries in the same register. Although the Gregorian calendar was not introduced in Utrecht until 30 November 1700, the gap is not in any way attributable to a difference between Old and New Style dating, for the final entry for 1623 in the same register is dated 23 December, the next one 4 January 1624—plainly a New Style, Gregorian dating. Nor does it make sense to consider "1625" a scribal error for "1624" for in that case the marriage would have taken place before the proclamation of the banns. All we can do is to accept the February 1625 date as a correct one and speculate that the marriage had been delayed for an indefinite length of time.

[11]Limon, *Gentlemen*, 100–101.

[12]Limon, "New Evidence," 118; and Limon, *Gentlemen*, 151.

[13]Hoppe, "English Acting Companies," 32.

[14]Vander Motten, "The Actor George Bentley," 87–91.

not the exclusive prerogative of the manager himself. But the explicit reference to "Bentley and his troupe" in the apprenticeship contract of 5 September 1646 raises the question whether he had by then, hardly two weeks after the August 24 attestation, left Jolly's company and set out on his own. Admittedly, two weeks may have been too short a time for Bentley to assemble an entirely new troupe but one in existence prior to the spring or summer of 1646 could easily have moved on and followed its pre-planned itinerary after a secession from Jolly. As I have proposed, George Bentley rather than Jolly may have been the "Mr Joris cum suis" whose appearance was recorded at Breda in 1646 (see above) and at 's Hertogenbosch prior to 1 August 1647.[15] If Bentley was the "Master George" who led this 1646 and/or 1647 acting company, neither he nor the ageing and seasoned actor John Wayde may have been affiliated with Jolly's troupe in a legally binding sense in the summer of 1646. Wayde and Bentley, as the respective heads of their own company, may have agreed to co-operate loosely with Jolly and recognized him as the unofficial *primus inter pares* for one season, without subscribing to the mutual obligations that were usually laid down in actors' and rope dancers' collaboration agreements in the Low Countries.[16] Although both men were evidently prepared to uphold Jolly's claim and testify on his behalf, the "contract" to which they referred in the notarial act had been concluded with a Dutch partner and his companions.

The major new piece of information provided by the August 24 act is the fact that Jolly's men (and women?) had been performing "at fairs, and acted in comedies and tragedies", in co-operation with the troupe led by "one Jean Babtista" (or "Jan Baptista"). This was the adoptive name of Jan Baptist van Fornenbergh (1624–1697), who was to become one of the most versatile and widely-travelled Dutch actors, company managers, dramatists, and theatrical entrepreneurs of the century.[17] In August 1646, however, Jan Baptist was only at the start of his long and fruitful career. Trained as a fencer and a comedian, van Fornenbergh had made his debut in the recently opened "Amsterdamse Schouwburg" (Theatre) in 1640, playing minor and incidental roles in tragedies by the greatest of all Dutch seventeenth-century authors, Joost van den Vondel (1587–1679). Between November 1642 and July 1643 and February until October 1645, two periods interspersed with foreign travel, Jan Baptist's name had turned up regularly in the list of payments to actors on the Amsterdam stage. Two of his fellow-performers there were Triael Parkar (Trial Parker, 1619/20-1673), an Amsterdam-born ballet dancer of English descent, and the boy actor and singer Gillis (Jillis) Nooseman (Amsterdam, 1627—The Hague, 1682). Gradually tiring of the established theatre, the enterprising Jan Baptist, thanks to a modest sum of money obtained from his wife, soon set up his own company of travelling performers and by the autumn of 1645 had begun to ally himself with various English expatriate actors. The first of these was John Payne, whose presence at The Hague (together with one John Butler) is first recorded on 23 October 1639.[18] On 31 October 1645, Payne and Jan Baptist, calling themselves "Engelsche commedianten", had rented a set of nine theatre costumes from one Aldert

[15]Vander Motten, "The Actor George Bentley," 91.
[16]Vander Motten and Roscam Abbing, "Seventeenth-Century English Rope Dancers."
[17]Most of my information on van Fornenbergh in the present paragraph is derived from Ben Albach's detailed study of the actor's life and career, *Langs Kermissen en Hoven*. Albach makes no mention of either of the notarial acts discussed here.
[18]GAH1. Notarieel archief. Notaris W. Rietraet, Minuutakten, 1638–1662. No. 163, p. 188.

Jacobsz. de Vrient, a Leiden publican. The notarial act recording the transaction stipulated that the costumes, rented for a sum of 26 guilders, were to be used in Payne's and Jan Baptist's "comedies, tragedies, and other plays" until Shrove Tuesday next (in 1646, this fell on or about 20 February).[19] What other actors belonged to this troupe is unknown; nor is it clear whether this particular alliance survived until February 1646. But we do know that on 28 March 1646 Payne and Jan Baptist, together with Nooseman, Abraham Sybant (ca. 1620?–ca. 1660?), Salomon Fino (born ca. 1622), Johannes Vercam, and Abraham Hendriksen had agreed to start collaborating in a new company for a period of one year, starting on 1 May 1646. Included in the March 1646 contract was the name of Jan Baptist's new associate, William Roe, who also served as the company's co-manager. Roe was an English-born but Utrecht-based actor, who had married a Dutchwoman in September 1631 and been a resident of the city for more than 15 years.[20] However, Payne-Roe's and Jan Baptist's projected co-operation failed to materialize, and their contract was probably called off before the summer of 1646. On 3 September, indeed, Jan Baptist and his companions Nooseman, Sybant, and Fino—now no longer "English comedians" but self-styled "masters of the Dutch comedians" [my translation]—drew up a new contract, which included the newcomer Bartholomeus van Velsen, who had been recently hired to act as their business manager.[21] In this new contract, Payne and Roe remained, significantly enough, unmentioned. Both must have gone their own way as travelling performers, perhaps in the wake of internal dissension with Jan Baptist and his Dutch fellow-actors.[22]

In view, then, of the date of the first notarial contract examined here—24 August—and its reference to the summer "fairs" (see below), I suspect that by the late spring or early summer of 1646 Jan Baptist had taken over the management of the English-Dutch collaborative venture (as envisaged in March 1646) and replaced Payne and Roe with George Jolly and his companions Wayde and Bentley. That Jan Baptist should have entered into a partnership with yet other English associates may not be surprising in view of his earlier ties with Payne and Roe. As a neophyte manager supervising a troupe of young, largely inexperienced travelling actors in 1645 and 1646, he may have hoped to benefit from the professional advice and international contacts of these seasoned English performers. Or he may have been impelled by (misguided) financial considerations, which can be shown to have played a part in his alliance with Jolly (see below). Although we may never learn why Jan Baptist concluded a cooperation agreement with Jolly, we can at least formulate a reliable hypothesis as to how both actors came within each other's ken.

[19]GAL1. Notarissen ter Standplaats Leiden (Oud Notarieel Archief). 752: Minuutacten van notaris Arendt Joachimsz. Raven, 1645–1646. Akte no. 80. 31 October 1645. The costumes are itemized in Albach, 59.

[20]The banns of "Wilhelmus Roo, bachelor, from England, and Maria van den Bongart, unmarried young woman, from Utrecht" [my translation] were proclaimed in that city on 14 August 1631 (see UA2. 711: Burgerlijke stand gemeente Utrecht. Inv. No. 95, p. 41). The couple were married at Amsterdam on 18 September (see GAA1. 5001: Archief van de Burgerlijke Stand). Roe spent the remainder of his life at Utrecht, where he died on 29 January 1662: see UA3. 711: Burgerlijke stand gemeente Utrecht. Inv. 124, folio 415. Maria Bongaerts (one of the variant spellings of her name), "widow of the late Willem Roo," was buried at Utrecht on 3 August 1663, apparently childless and leaving only an adult sister. Her belongings are described as "half a house, encumbered" [i.e. with a mortgage] (see UA3. 711: Burgerlijke stand gemeente Utrecht, Inv. 124, folio 555).

[21]This was one of three separate agreements made by the Dutch actors on 3 and 10 September, immediately after the split between Jan Baptist and Jolly (see below).

[22]Albach, *Langs Kermissen*, 59–60.

It is highly likely that even before the summer of 1646 Roe and Wayde, who signed the August 24 act, and presumably Payne, had become associated with their fellow-countryman Jolly. Firstly, such association would have been facilitated by the men's marital ties to Utrecht-born women. Like Roe and Maria van den Bongart, on the one hand, and Wayde and Jannechjen van Es (see above), on the other, Jolly and his wife "Maria di Roy" (a variant of "de Roij"?) were residents of Utrecht long before they started out on their travels through Germany in the 1650s.[23] It is improbable that the three expatriate actors, living in the same city, should have been unaware of each other's theatrical activities and not at some point have wanted to pool their resources. Secondly, ever since December 1613 and July 1620, when John Green (fl. 1603-1626) had requested permission to play at Utrecht, troupes of English and French itinerant players, most of them unnamed, had visited the city on a regular basis. As a matter of fact, as early as the summer of 1621, ten years before his marriage, William Roe (born ca. 1591) had been a member of John Green's company then based at Utrecht.[24] Even English noblemen and officers, amateur actors billeting in the city, had performed a comedy there in December 1633 and January 1634.[25] And on 8 July 1645, Roe and his "Engelsche Commedianten" had asked the local authorities for permission to stage "various strange and noble tragedies of old histories during the annual fair."[26] As appears to have been the case with Roe, then, Utrecht's decades-long relative hospitality to foreign players may have lured Jolly to the city, either singly or as a member of a hitherto unidentified troupe. His hopes for the financial gain that a place not averse to play performances could offer a foreign actor may have influenced his decision to settle down there. Both Roe and Wayde, being established and well-travelled actors familiar with the European entertainment landscape, could well have served as serviceable points of contact when Jolly first arrived in the Low Countries. Thirdly, Jan Baptist as well as Nooseman and Sybant, two of Jan Baptist's men and co-signatories of the August 27 attestation (see below) who evidently knew Jolly well, had already contracted to join forces with Payne and Roe in March 1646, as already pointed out. There is, in other words, sufficient reason to assume that Jolly must have partly owed his affiliation with his Dutch peers to the professional links that his fellow-countrymen John Payne, William Roe, John Wayde, and George Bentley had established in the recent past.

[23]One of the few facts to have emerged about Jolly in the past 120 years is an entry in the baptismal register of St. Sebald's in Nürnberg, recording his wife's name and that of a child on 29 December 1659: "Georgius Jeliphus von Chelse in Midllsex bey London ein Comoediant. Maria di Roy von Utrecht in Holland." See Worp, "Die englischen Komödianten." Based on the resemblance of the names, Worp speculated that "di Roy" was possible William Rowe[sic]'s daughter, his sister or his widow, which would have made Jolly Roe's son-in-law or brother-in-law—a supposition shared by Riewald, "New Light", 90–91. Katritzky has stated that Rowe [sic] "has been identified as the probable father of Jolly's wife" (*Women, Medicine,* 276). As has been detailed above, Roe and his wife remained childless. If the date of Jolly's and di Roy's marriage could be discovered, this would provide the most reliable indication about the actor's earliest presence in Holland. We cannot be sure that "di Roy" was the mother of both the child christened at Nürnberg in December 1659 and of George Jolly's son "born in the house of Mathew Smith Player" on 9 July 1640 in London (see Bentley, *Jacobean,* 484). The latter date probably implies that Jolly did not depart for the continent until after July 1640.

[24]UA4. Utrechts Archief 34–4: Notarissen in de stad Utrecht. Inv. no. 72: Notaris C. Verduyn, act no. 29 (10 August 1621). See my forthcoming article "The Actors John Green (fl. 1606–1627), William Roe (c. 1591–1662), and a Pair of Gloves", in *Notes and Queries*, 72 (2025).

[25]van Sorgen, *De Tooneelspeelkunst*, 14–18, 75, 78–79; and Kossmann, *Nieuwe bijdragen,* 141–142.

[26]van Sorgen, 75. The request, submitted on Roe's behalf by the widow of Johan van Zuijlen, lord of the manor of Soestbergen, describes Roe as being "alhier binnen Utrecht getrouwt, gehuijst end gehoofd", literally "married and having a house and garden at Utrecht."

It is unclear whether this English-Dutch association was a strictly commercial one, with two troupes independently working alongside each other but sharing the costs and the profits, or an artistically integrated one, with both Jolly's and Jan Baptist's men (and women?) acting parts in the same play. The latter is perhaps the more likely hypothesis, even though the phrasing of the August 24 attestation ("… have played *next to* one Jean Babtista as a company") is somewhat ambiguous in this respect. Nor does this document allow us to determine for how long Jolly and Jan Baptist had collaborated. But the statement that they had done so at "fairs" (plural), which were usually held in the spring and summer seasons, beginning at The Hague in May and ending at Amsterdam in late September, suggests that their co-operation may have lasted for some three months, perhaps from May until July 1646.[27] The fact remains, however, that George Jolly's name does not feature in either of the contracts that Jan Baptist and his companions, Dutch as well as English, are known to have concluded, with John Payne in or before October 1645, and with Payne and Roe on 28 March 1646 (see above). Then again, determining an actor's membership of any one itinerant company at a particular moment in time is bound to be fraught with uncertainty. Despite the strict injunctions laid down in notarial acts regarding the premature termination of contractual obligations, companies were formed and dissolved at the drop of a hat. And their composition was in a constant state of flux, with members absconding or moving from one troupe to another without much ado. This is what appears to have happened here. Jan Baptist's troupe had seceded from the association with Jolly and his partners and had gone off to try their fortunes at the Gouda fair, which began on the first Monday after 25 July, Saint James Day—30 July in 1646.[28] According to the August 24 attestation, Jan Baptist had done so without any intention of paying a debt of 60 guilders he owed Jolly for the use of theatre costumes as well as for money advanced by him for undisclosed purposes. That the Dutch actor and his men were in the English manager's debt and not the other way around virtually proves that the management of their short-lived, amalgamated troupe had been in Jolly's hands. But in the absence of a notarized, written co-operation agreement, if any there was, it is impossible to make any inferences about the specific financial arrangements the two men had made.

Even before Jolly and his fellow-actors had their August 24 attestation recorded by notary Hofflant, they had taken their complaint to the "Vreedemakers Camer" (lit. the "Chamber of Peacemakers"), Rotterdam's arbitrating board, a body of three or four commissioners who had jurisdiction in minor civil cases, including claims and disputes opposing masters and servants or individual members of the trade guilds.[29] The commissioners were authorized to pronounce judgment on financial claims brought before them, as long as these did not exceed sixty guilders—(co-incidentally?) the exact amount demanded by Jolly. On 25 August 1646, the day after Wayde and Bentley made their declaration on behalf of Jolly, the arbitrators heard both parties, including Jan Baptist, as appears from the second notarial act to be briefly examined here, dated 27 August 1646.[30] Signed before notary Jacobus Delphius, this was a statement by three of Jan Baptist's men, which deserves to be quoted in a near-complete form:

[27]On Holland's fairs in the early modern period, see Sierman, "'Ten profijte."
[28]Abels, Goudriaan, en Habermehl, e.a., *Duizend jaar,* 702.
[29]Unger, *De Regeering,* liii-lv.
[30]SAR2. 18: Notarissen te Rotterdam en daarin opgegane gemeenten. Notaris Jacobius Delphius. Akte no. 42, pp. 76–77. Delphius had been appointed on 9 April 1633. His collections span the period 7 June 1634–21 June 1670.

Today, on the 27th of August 1646, have appeared before me etc. Bartholomeus van Velsen, from The Hague, twenty-two years old, Gillis Noseman, from Amsterdam, twenty years old, and Abraham Sybants, also from Amsterdam, nineteen years old, or each of them about that age, who have declared the following in true words instead of a regular oath, at the request of Jan Baptist van Foornenburch. On Saturday 25 last of the present month of August, the deponents and the petitioner [i.e. Jan Baptist] have been present in the chambers of the College of the Peacemakers of the city of Rotterdam and have therefore also heard that Iores Jolijff [i.e. George Jolly], with some of his companions, claimants, demanded [payment of] <a sum of 60 guilders>, a debt which he the petitioner, having been in a company [of actors] with them, allegedly still owes them. The petitioner replied that it could not possibly have been such a high amount; and he asked Jolijff and his companions whether they did not know, as he said he very well did, that at the time when he the petitioner joined the company, <the company> was already in debt to the tune of one hundred <and twenty-four> guilders. To which the aforesaid Joris Jolijff replied that at the time of the petitioner's arrival there was an outstanding debt of only 110 guilders with some other [illegible word] debts and he promised to provide and present the petitioner with all the relevant accounts by Monday [three illegible words] … Signed: B. Van Velsen, Gillis Nooseman, Abraham Sibandt.[31]

By 25 August, then, Jan Baptist had evidently returned to Rotterdam from the Gouda fair, which had started on 30 July (see above)—perhaps he had done so at the invitation of, or in answer to a summons from, the Rotterdam Chamber of Peacemakers. Intended as a response recording Jan Baptist's version of the facts, his fellow-actors' declaration leaves no doubt that it was he—a 22-year-old, possibly impecunious actor—who had entered into a partnership with Jolly's troupe. If Jan Baptist did so on the assumption that Jolly's was a financially viable company that could lend him the theatre costumes and the money mentioned in the act of 24 August, why did he argue before the arbitrators that he had known perfectly well that Jolly's troupe had been in (unspecified) arrears to the tune of 124 guilders at the time when he joined it?[32] Knowledgeable about the company finances as he made

[31]In my translation, I have introduced some punctuation marks and added a few words of clarification in square brackets. I have also omitted the concluding formula and indicated hard to decipher or illegible passages. Interlinear insertions in the original are given between pointed brackets; contracted words have been silently expanded. The Dutch text reads as follows: "/p. 76/ Op huijden den 27en Augusti 1646 compareerden etc. Bartholomeus van Velsen uijt 's Gravenhage out 22 Jaeren Gillis Noseman van Amsterdam out 20 Jaeren ende Abraham Sybants mede van Amsterdam out 19 Jaren oft elck daer omtrent, ende verclaerden bij haeren mannen waerheden in plaetse van rechten Ede ter requisitie ende versoucke van Jan Baptist Van Foornenburch warachtich te sijn hoe dat sij deposanten op Saterdach den 25en deses loopenden Maents Augusti Inden Vreedemakers Camer in Collegie vande heeren Vreedemakers deser stede Rotteren beneffens den req^{t} daer bij en present geweest sijn, en mitsdesen oock gehoort hebben dat Jores Jolijff met enige van sijne complicen die requiranten waren oft eijsschers voortgene hij requirant als met haer in Compagnie geweest sijnde aende selve persoon rente zoude schuldig gebleven sijn, <de somme van tsestich gulden> waer op hij requirant zeijde als dat het niet mogelijk was dat het soo veel zoude connen sijn, ende vraechde verder aen voorseide Jolijff met zijne complicen oft zij mede [niet wel?] en wisten gelijck hij requirant zeijde wel te weten, als dat ten tijde als hij requirant bijde Compagnie quam <de Compagnie> al hondert <vierentwintich> gulden ten achteren <was> daer op den voors: Joris Jolijff antwoorde en seijde datter ten tijde van zijn requirants aencompste maer hondert en tien gul: ten achteren was met noch enige … schulden, ende belooffde den /p. 77/ requirant op Maenendach … van de [letters lost in the gutter] pertinente rekening van alles te leveren [ende?] presenteren Ende Aldus gedaen en gepasseert binnen de vs: stadt Rotteren ter presentie van Adryan de … ende Willem Sonnevelt mijnen Clercq als getuijgen hiertoe gerequireert. Signed: van Velsen, Gillis Nooseman, Abraham Sibandt."

[32]The high over-all debt of 110 or 124 guilders owed by Jolly might be indicative of incurred expenses that far exceeded the sum total of back wages only and might have been spent on costly items such as clothes, scenery, and theatre

himself out to be, if Jan Baptist felt that his debt of 60 guilders was disproportionately large in comparison to the total arrears he claimed Jolly's company had fallen into, why did he not present the arbitrators with the correct amount of the money he owed? In the absence of documentary evidence about Jolly's and Jan Baptist's cooperation agreement and the financial operations of their short-lived united company, neither question can be meaningfully answered. How relevant and convincing, on the other hand, was Jolly's argument that his company's debts amounted to no more than 110 guilders, still a considerable sum, and how did this reflect favourably on the fairness of his claim? Perhaps his claim was no more than a shrewd ploy to recoup part of his losses at Jan Baptist's expense. If it was, it certainly would have been of a piece with the reputation of a cantankerous, litigious, and money-grubbing manager which Jolly was to gain in the 1650s and after the Restoration.[33] I have found no indication as to how the "Peacemakers" ruled but within a matter of days Jan Baptist and Jolly must have parted ways.[34] On 3 and 10 September 1646, Jan Baptist and his company of "nederduytsche Commedianten" made three separate agreements relating to their recruitment of new members as well as to the term of their projected co-operation.[35] As already pointed out, in none of these is there so much as an allusion to Jolly, Wayde, Bentley, or any other English actor, such as Payne and Roe, with whom they had been associated in the recent past. And after 27 August 1646, it is not until March 1649 that we have any unmistakable evidence about Jolly's whereabouts, as Robert Alexander's investigations have made clear (Figure 2).

We can do no more than speculate about the nature of the shows at fairgrounds and the subjects of the "comedies and tragedies"—a ubiquitous phrase without any reliable generic implications—in which Jolly, Jan Baptist, and their companions had appeared, according to the August 24 attestation. But we can be confident about the language in which they were presented. In the 1590s the earliest companies of itinerant actors, performing in English in Germany, had found it necessary to attract uncomprehending local audiences using music, dancing, clowning, and a good many indecencies. By about 1620, however, when local comedians (German and Dutch) had come to associate themselves with their English colleagues, the latter no longer exclusively played in their native language.[36] Another twenty-five years later the repertory of the Jolly-Jan Baptist company must have included plays at least partly if not entirely in Dutch as well as Dutch-language versions of old Elizabethan plays. Adaptations of such English materials had been part of the widely disseminated "German" repertories of the previous decades and might have been passed on to the Jolly-Jan Baptist troupe through the intermediary of English and Dutch actors active in the Netherlands.[37] Whatever the case may have

props. For comparison: the earnings of an average actor in the Amsterdam Theatre, no doubt a more prestigious institution than a travelling stage, came to a modest 3 guilders a week. See Blom, *Podium*, 70–3.

[33]Herz, *Englische Schauspieler*, 59; and Hotson, *Commonwealth and Restoration Stage*, 169–171.

[34]An answer is unlikely to be available for the Vredemakers' archives appear to have been largely lost.

[35]All three have been published by Haverkorn van Rijsewijk, in "De Rederijkerskamer," 154–157.

[36]Limon, *Gentlemen*, 12–19; Albach, *Langs Kermissen*, 20–21.

[37]German-language versions of Kyd's *Spanish Tragedy* and Marlowe's *The Jew of Malta* had featured in the repertory of John Green, when he performed at the Dresden Court from May through September 1626, some five years after his association with William Roe in Utrecht (see above). The famous collection of *Engelische Comedien und Tragedien*, anonymously published at Leipzig in 1620, also included a "very lamentable Tragedy" (my translation) of *Titus Andronicus*. See: Haekel, *Die Englischen Komödianten*, 111–14, 129–30; and Blom, *Podium*, 98–126.

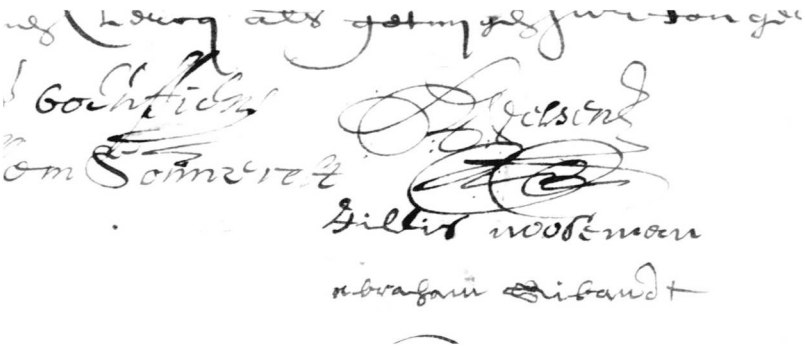

Figure 2. Stadsarchief Rotterdam. 18: Notarissen te Rotterdam en daarin opgegane gemeenten. Inv. 392: Notary Jacobus Delphius, 8 January 1646–29 December 1650. Act no. 42: attestation dated 27 August 1646, p. 77. Signatures of Bartholomeus van Velsen, Gillis Nooseman, and Abraham Sibandt.

been, some of Jolly's men must have had a good enough grasp of Dutch to allow them to play parts in that language.[38] As far as John Wayde was concerned, the challenge cannot have been a very daunting one for by 1646 he had lived in the Low Countries for more than two decades (see above). Even Jolly himself, who had married a Dutchwoman, may have been sufficiently integrated in local society to take on Dutch speaking parts. And it must be borne in mind that some of the adapted or translated stories in their repertory, having at one time been shown on the London stage, would have been familiar territory to the English actors and therefore have lent themselves to production without unduly long preparation.[39]

As to actual play titles, we are admittedly groping in the dark. In so far, however, as he chose to include contemporary, native comedies in the repertoire, Jan-Baptist could have easily drawn on the support of a playwright within his own ranks. The prolific Gillis Nooseman was the author of a good many farces, the first three of which were given at the Amsterdam Theatre in the years 1644-1646.[40] *Hans van Tongen*, published in 1644, was performed seventeen times as an afterpiece; *Lichte Klaertje* [Wanton Little Clara] was staged some eighty times between its première on 16 October 1645 and 1665; and his *Beroyde Student* [The Destitute Student] was first produced on 7 August 1646—around the time of the Jolly-Jan Baptist co-operation. Inspired by Boccaccio's *Decameron*, the first two share with Nooseman's other comic skits the themes of marital infidelity, deceit, male stupidity, and drunkenness. With their realistic settings and recognizable characters, their bustling action, and catchy rhyming lines, Nooseman's widely applauded comedies might have been the kind of dramatic fare with which the Jolly-

[38]One such strolling actor was the Utrecht rhetorician Adriaen van den Bergh (fl. 1621/22- died after 1652): he had been a member of the Butler-Payne company in 1639 (see above) and as such had no doubt acquired an intimate knowledge of their repertory. See Kossmann, *Nieuwe bijdragen,* 144.

[39]*Aran en Titus*, a revenge tragedy by the neophyte dramatist Jan Vos (1610/11–1667), might have shown the Jolly-Jan Baptist troupe the shortest way to public approval. Ready for rehearsal as early as 1638 and first performed to general acclaim at the Amsterdam Theatre on 30 September 1641—around the time when Jan Baptist made his debut there—this rewriting of *Titus Andronicus* satisfied the public's thirst for action, sensation and "sadistic violence." See Albach, *Langs Kermissen,* 47–49. On the popularity of this play in Germany, see Lukas Erne, Florence Hazrat, and Maria Shmygol, eds., *Early Modern German Shakespeare*, 47–52.

[40]Information based on: Grootegoed, van Leuvensteijn en Rebel, Jillis Nooseman, *"Beroyde Student"* en *"Bedrooge Dronkkaart"*.

Jan Baptist troupe chose to regale their audiences during the spring and summer of 1646.[41] But until new evidence emerges, this too must remain a matter for speculation.

While enlightening us as to Jolly's Dutch professional contacts, the notarial acts of 24 and 27 August 1646 frustratingly enough raise more questions than they resolve. How was the dispute between Jolly and Jan Baptist settled, if at all? Is there an extant co-operation contract of this united English-Dutch company, one laying down their mutual commitments as well as their planned circuit and financial and logistical arrangements? What was the original size of this troupe that was disbanded in late August 1646, not too long after its creation? Did it number any other expatriate English actors other than Wayde and Bentley? In addition to Rotterdam, which cities or other stopping places, Dutch or foreign, were meant to be included in their itinerary? Apart from marketplaces or other fairground locations, what acting spaces were assigned to them by the local authorities or possibly put at their disposal by a generous patron—a hall, a tennis court, an inn, or some merchant's home? Depending on the individual specialties of the company personnel (perhaps including dancers, acrobats, and clowns) and the available scenic facilities, is it imaginable that Jolly at this early point in time introduced women and used expensive costumes and scenery in his/their productions, elements that he is known to have experimented with on a more ambitious scale during his tours in Germany in 1653–1654?[42] And most importantly perhaps, what productions of some complexity in terms of their casts, scenic requirements, and play-texts was this mixed company capable of staging?

Not until further archival evidence is unearthed will we be able to answer some of these questions. Although they provide no more than a snapshot of the life of one itinerant company, the notarial acts discussed here must nevertheless be welcomed as the most reliable evidence available to date about George Jolly's early career in the Netherlands, which may now be safely taken to have begun in the spring or summer of 1646 at the latest.

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[41]It may be noted that, although not yet a practising playwright in 1646, Abraham Sybant too was to gain distinction, as one of the earliest Dutch Shakespeare translators-adaptors. On 9 November 1654, *De dolle Bruyloft* [The Mad Wedding], an adaptation of *The Taming of the Shrew*, was performed at the Amsterdam Theatre, and printed the same year. *De verleyde vriendt* [The Seduced Friend], Sybant's adaptation of James Shirley's *Love's Cruelty* (c. 1631), was also performed at Amsterdam on 26 August 1655 but did not appear in print until 1668. See van Nassau-Sarolea, "Abraham Sybant" and Erne, Hazrat, and Shmygol, Early Modern German Shakespeare, 125–7.

[42]Hotson, *Commonwealth and Restoration Stage,* 170–1.

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